

MIT Overview and History

Basic Facts

Full Name: Massachusetts Institute of Technology

Founded: April 10, 1861

Location: Cambridge, Massachusetts, USA

Campus Size: 168 acres

Type: Private research university

Motto: Mens et Manus, which means Mind and Hand

Endowment: Approximately 24.6 billion US dollars as of fiscal year 2023

Number of Nobel Laureates among alumni and faculty: 97

Total student enrollment: approximately 11,500 undergraduate and graduate students

Number of faculty members: approximately 1,000

Official website: web.mit.edu

Founding

MIT was founded on April 10, 1861, when Governor John A. Andrew signed its act of incorporation. The institute was conceived by William Barton Rogers, a natural scientist who believed that scientific knowledge should be taught alongside practical applications. This philosophy is captured in the motto Mens et Manus, meaning Mind and Hand. Because of the Civil War, formal instruction did not begin until 1865, when MIT opened its doors in Boston's Back Bay neighborhood.

Relocation and Early Growth (1900 to 1940)

By the early 20th century MIT had outgrown its Boston facilities. In 1916 the institute relocated across the Charles River to its current 168-acre campus in Cambridge, Massachusetts. The new campus was designed by architect William Welles Bosworth and features the iconic Great Dome on Building 10 and the Infinite Corridor, a quarter-mile-long hallway connecting the main buildings. During this period MIT forged strong ties with industry and pioneered the model of university-industry collaboration that would become a global standard.

World War II and the Radiation Laboratory (1940 to 1950)

World War II transformed MIT into a major hub of wartime research. The MIT Radiation Laboratory, established in 1940, developed microwave radar that proved decisive in the Allied war effort. At its peak the lab employed nearly 4,000 scientists and engineers and produced roughly half of the radar equipment used by Allied forces. This period cemented MIT's reputation as a leading institution for

defense-related and applied research.

Post-War Expansion and Computing (1950 to 1980)

The post-war decades saw explosive growth in enrollment and research. MIT researchers made landmark contributions to computing, including Project Whirlwind, which led to the first real-time digital computer. The institute expanded into life sciences, economics, and management, establishing the Sloan School of Management in 1952. MIT launched the Undergraduate Research Opportunities Program in 1969, enabling students to collaborate directly with faculty on cutting-edge research.

Modern Era (1980 to Present)

In recent decades MIT has remained at the forefront of artificial intelligence, biotechnology, climate science, and public policy. The MIT Media Lab was founded in 1985. In 2002 MIT launched OpenCourseWare, making course materials from thousands of classes freely available online. In 2011 MIT launched MITx, which evolved into the edX online learning platform serving millions of learners worldwide. MIT faculty and alumni have founded more than 30,000 companies generating an estimated 1.9 trillion dollars in annual revenue and approximately 4.6 million jobs worldwide.

The Five Schools and One College at MIT

MIT is organized into five schools and one college. The School of Architecture and Planning covers architecture, urban studies and planning, and the Media Lab. The School of Engineering is MIT's largest school and includes departments such as Aeronautics and Astronautics, Chemical Engineering, Civil and Environmental Engineering, Electrical Engineering and Computer Science, Materials Science, Mechanical Engineering, and Nuclear Science and Engineering. The School of Humanities Arts and Social Sciences includes Economics, Linguistics and Philosophy, History, Literature, Music and Theater Arts, Political Science, and Science Technology and Society. The MIT Sloan School of Management is a world-renowned business school. The School of Science houses Biology, Brain and Cognitive Sciences, Chemistry, Earth Atmospheric and Planetary Sciences, Mathematics, and Physics. The Schwarzman College of Computing was established in 2019 and focuses on computing, artificial intelligence, and their ethical and societal implications.